

The Watch the Clock card, from zero — four faces · four footprints · ember nights · second skies · the ghost

The most-looked-at card, designed from what little it knows: the device's own time, a date, at most a place. That poverty is the design — everything on the face is the time, or it isn't there. Four complete faces below, each carried across all four footprints, each alive in exactly one honest way — the ticking figure, and the slow turn to ember after dark. Meridian floats the figure. Waterline stands it on the day's one line. Bell says it aloud. Beacon fills the card like an instrument.

Space runs tight → seconds go first → then the date → then the place → the time — never

The clock never says "Clock"

The SERVICE - WIDGET caption every card wears is chrome a clock doesn't need — a clock is self-evident. Local clocks are anonymous; a second clock wears its place as its only label (1b).

Motion is the data

Seconds tick, or the face settles once a minute; the day-mark creeps a pixel every four minutes; dusk turns the palette over three hours. Nothing else moves. The one live card in this file is 1b.

One card, one place

A world clock is several clock cards, never one card of many cities. On Waterline the offsets become visible distance between marks on the same line (1c).

Night belongs to the Clock alone

After dark the Clock recolors to the ember tokens, exactly; the field and every neighbor stays asleep in the normal palette (1b, 1f).

Scope: faces render at phone scale on the real grid — two 173px columns of 86px rows, 12px gutters (S 173×86 · M 173×204 · W 358×86 · L 358×204); the wall is a 1024×640 stage drawing the same footprints larger. One consistent Saturday — July 11, 2026 — in every frame except 1h, which is this device, live. The Clock's interior is designed from zero per the brief; its shell keeps the card tokens verbatim, and every neighbor is the settled WidgeCard. Web stands in for React Native.

1a The spine — one skeleton under every face four footprints on the 96px grid, and the order in which detail gives way

Large · 2×2
358×204 — the wall hero

Medium · 1×2
173×204

Wide · 2×1
358×96 — the banner

Small · 1×1
173×96

When space runs tight, detail gives way — in order

- Seconds** — first to go; off, the face settles once a minute.
- The date** — Small drops it; a second-clock Small keeps its place instead.
- The place** — only when even one caption can't breathe.
- The time** — never. It is the card.

And always: the time is the brightest thing on the face; tabular figures so a tick never jitters; inner padding steps up a spacing rung with the card — 12, 16, 24.

The dashboard grid: two columns, 86px rows, 12px gutters. Every face below fits both width and height at all four — nothing clips, nothing floats in dead space.

1b FACE A — MERIDIAN The figure, alone dead-center, no chrome; everything else orbits at a whisper

PHONE · SATURDAY MORNING

Large 2×2 · the night face, seconds on — 11:07:44 PM

Medium 1×2 · the date joins

Wide 2×1 · a second clock — the place is the only label it ever wears

Small 1×1 · the bedside glance

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The control face — nothing but the figure, optically centered at every footprint, so the card reads as a point of light with a number in it. Seconds, when on, slack under the meridian at a whisper. This is the face the other three argue with.

Among captioned neighbors, the caption-less clock reads as the sky's fixed star — the one card that is a thing, not a report.

THE WALL · ACROSS THE ROOM, 6:05 AM

Large 2×2 · the night face, seconds on — 11:07:44 PM

Medium 1×2 · the date joins

Wide 2×1 · a second clock — the place is the only label it ever wears

Small 1×1 · the bedside glance

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The centered stance holds at wall scale — the figure sits at the hero card's optical middle, not anchored to a corner, so from across the room the tile reads whole; a lit face, not a layout.

1c FACE B — WATERLINE The day, drawn once one hairline is the whole day, midnight to midnight, noon at the notch — the mark is the time, placed on it

PHONE · A WORLD CLOCK IS SEVERAL CARDS

Large 2×2 · right — the mark near the line's end; the day nearly spent

Medium 1×2 · the line runs the card's long axis — the day falls top to bottom

Wide 2×1 · second clock — its mark, its day, its date

Small 1×1 · time and line — the date went, the day stayed

When space runs tight, detail gives way — in order

- Seconds** — first to go; off, the face settles once a minute.
- The date** — Small drops it; a second-clock Small keeps its place instead.
- The place** — only when even one caption can't breathe.
- The time** — never. It is the card.

And always: the time is the brightest thing on the face; tabular figures so a tick never jitters; inner padding steps up a spacing rung with the card — 12, 16, 24.

Meridian's figure, stood on the hero: the time the way a person answers the question. Words round to the nearest five minutes — so the exact figure always stands beneath them, and the sentence resettles only twelve times an hour, the calmest cadence of the four. Noon and midnight get their own words.

One card, one place — and the rule pays off: three waterlines stack, and the offsets read as distance between marks. Tokyo's mark sits in early morning, its date already turned to Sunday. New York trails yours by the width of an afternoon.

THE WALL · ACROSS THE ROOM, 2:41 PM

Large 2×2 · right — the mark near the line's end; the day nearly spent

Medium 1×2 · the line runs the card's long axis — the day falls top to bottom

Wide 2×1 · second clock — its mark, its day, its date

Small 1×1 · time and line — the date went, the day stayed

When space runs tight, detail gives way — in order

- Seconds** — first to go; off, the face settles once a minute.
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And always: the time is the brightest thing on the face; tabular figures so a tick never jitters; inner padding steps up a spacing rung with the card — 12, 16, 24.

The wall hero anchors the figure low and lets the line close the card — from the sofa you read the time, walking past, the mark just after the noon notch tells you where the day stands. Seconds ride at a whisper beside the meridian, the one ticking thing in the room.

1d FACE C — BELL The clock, said aloud the round words carry the glance; the exact figures keep the truth underneath

PHONE · SATURDAY, LATE AFTERNOON

Large 2×2 · right — the words in ember, the truth beneath

Medium 1×2 · words above, figures below

Wide 2×1 · second clock — a place, spoken to

Small 1×1 · the words stand alone

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Vela's plain voice, spent on the hero: the time the way a person answers the question. Words round to the nearest five minutes — so the exact figure always stands beneath them, and the sentence resettles only twelve times an hour, the calmest cadence of the four. Noon and midnight get their own words.

Against a sky of numbers, the one card made of words is unmistakably the clock — no caption needed. The exact line keeps the honesty contract with the rest of the wall.

THE WALL · ACROSS THE ROOM, 5:12 PM

Large 2×2 · right — the words in ember, the truth beneath

Medium 1×2 · words above, figures below

Wide 2×1 · second clock — a place, spoken to

Small 1×1 · the words stand alone

When space runs tight, detail gives way — in order

- Seconds** — first to go; off, the face settles once a minute.
- The date** — Small drops it; a second-clock Small keeps its place instead.
- The place** — only when even one caption can't breathe.
- The time** — never. It is the card.

And always: the time is the brightest thing on the face; tabular figures so a tick never jitters; inner padding steps up a spacing rung with the card — 12, 16, 24.

Two big words read across a room as fast as figures do — and warmer. The costs are real, though; the rounding argues with a brand that never fudges a number, and the words don't localize for free. Charm on trial; verdict at 1h.

1e FACE D — BEACON The instrument the figure fills the card's long axis, 24-hour by temperament — read from across dark water

PHONE · THE SAME AFTERNOON — 24-HOUR

Large 2×2 · right — the corners engraved, the figure everything else

Medium 1×2 · the stack — hours bright, minutes a step back

Wide 2×1 · second clock — place and date as engravings

Small 1×1 · nothing but the figure

When space runs tight, detail gives way — in order

- Seconds** — first to go; off, the face settles once a minute.
- The date** — Small drops it; a second-clock Small keeps its place instead.
- The place** — only when even one caption can't breathe.
- The time** — never. It is the card.

And always: the time is the brightest thing on the face; tabular figures so a tick never jitters; inner padding steps up a spacing rung with the card — 12, 16, 24.

The figure fills the long axis — in line on landscape cards, stacked on portrait ones, minutes one tint behind hours so the stack never reads as one number. Shown 24-hour, its best posture; 12-hour works. Date and seconds live in the corners like engravings on an instrument.

On the phone the fill presses against the 96px rhythm — commanding, but it out-shouts every neighbor: Beacon's argument is the wall.

THE WALL · 11:07 PM — THE NIGHT EMBER, IN PLACE

Large 2×2 · right — the corners engraved, the figure everything else

Medium 1×2 · the stack — hours bright, minutes a step back

Wide 2×1 · second clock — place and date as engravings

Small 1×1 · nothing but the figure

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The money shot of the night rule: one ember among quiet cards. The room reads the hour in deep red from any angle; nothing on the wall wakes, blinks, or blasts white. Hours bright, minutes a tint back — legible at twenty feet, gentle at two.

1f After dark — the ember ramp the one card that changes character; dusk eases it down, dawn lifts it back — shown on Waterline

6:58 PM
Saturday, July 11

8:24 PM
Saturday, July 11

11:07 PM
Saturday, July 11

6:58 PM · the day face, unlit

8:24 PM · mid-ramp — computed, not designed

11:07 PM · full ember — the tokens, verbatim

No sunset data, so the ramp is the clock's own: the palette eases from day to ember across 7–10 PM and lifts back across 5:30–7 AM, a shade a minute — nobody ever sees it change, the room just goes warm. Every color pair interpolates in step (figure, date, line, mark), so the face is coherent at any instant of dusk. Only the Clock ramps; the field and neighbors never recolor.

Always-on honesty: on an OLED wall, #0A0506 is effectively off — after dark the ember figure is the only lit thing in the room, at a wavelength that spares night vision. A burn-in pixel-shift study is queued in next steps.

1g The ghost — the picker's preview the one card that can never be empty previews itself live, un-lit, at true size

PHONE · ADDING THE CLOCK

ONLY TWO FACES, EVER

1 Live — the device clock always has a value, so there is no stale, no error, no empty, no skeleton. The Clock is the floor every other card's edge cases stand on.

2 Ghost — the un-lit preview above, real size, real time, waiting to be placed.

Settings ride the card, not the face; place (none, or one zone), 12/24-hour, seconds, date form — a Below Deck row-group, no new UI language.

Un-lit means no surface fill — light is what placing it buys. The ghost runs live even here: the Clock is the only card whose preview can use real data, because its data cannot fail. It never embers in the picker; ember is the earned dark of a placed card, not the catalog's.

1h The call — and the one live card a face has to earn its place on a wall that never turns off

The call — Waterline (1c). Meridian is the control, and between ticks it is furniture. Waterline adds exactly one element — the day as a hairline, the mark as the time placed on it — and the card sits at every place without one decorative pixel. The ladder holds at all four footprints, a place alive in over the figure with no new chrome, and after dark the mark near the line's end is the night told honestly, the day nearly spent. **Bell** stays a provocation — its rounding argues with a brand that never fudges a number, and its words don't localize for free. **Beacon** loses the phone but wins the dark; its posture is one 24-hour toggle away, and 1e's wall is the argument for keeping that toggle.

LIVE — THIS ONE IS YOUR CLOCK

1:24 PM
Saturday, July 11

Ticking from this device, now — seconds on, it moves once a second; off, it settles once a minute. It wears the 1f ramp by your local hour: visit after ten and this card is ember. Tweaks on this file: 24-hour · seconds · annotations.

Try next: "prototype the minute settle and the dusk ramp as a timed sequence". "Waterline's settings — place, 24-hour, seconds — as a Below Deck row-group". "the 3 AM burn-in shift study for the wall". "Beacon as the wall's optimal right posture, formalized." Tweaks: the live card in 1h takes 24-hour and seconds; annotations toggles the aside's.